HTTP Status Codes Cheat Sheet

Which status code should my API return?

Code	Name	Use it when...
200	OK	A GET or PUT succeeded and you return data
201	Created	POST created a new resource
204	No Content	Success, nothing to return (e.g. DELETE)
400	Bad Request	The input is invalid (missing field, wrong format)
401	Unauthorized	No token, or the token is invalid / expired
403	Forbidden	Logged in, but not allowed (wrong role, not the owner)
404	Not Found	The resource does not exist
409	Conflict	The request clashes with current state (duplicate, already paid)
500	Internal Server Error	Unexpected bug on the server

401 vs 403

401 means "who are you?" — the user must log in. **403** means "I know who you are, but you can't do this" — logging in again will not help.

400 vs 409

400 is about the request itself being wrong. **409** means the request is fine but the current data does not allow it, for example applying twice to the same course.

Consistent error bodies

```
{
  "statusCode": 409,
  "message": "You already applied to this course."
}
```